Gregory Possehl sees Dholavira as ‘a regional center of authority, a hub of communications, an ancient caravanserai for traders and travelers’.

The Harappans seem to have lived in a heterarchy rather than a hierarchy, implying that across the entire Harappan realm, there was no overarching authority. Its far-flung regional centres were likely independent and decentralized, but localized hierarchies of power can be inferred from the plan of their cities. Further, their public works required a steady supply of labour, likely funded by taxes. What also unified them across the entire region was a common material culture (and perhaps a substantially common spiritual culture), though they were also ethnically diverse and had distinctive local features and priorities.

For instance, the Harappans were united by a common writing system. They had a uniform system of weights and measures, starting with a 50 mg weight, an astonishing feat of precision for its day. They all made similar beads, bangles, pottery and square seals. Their metallurgy was alike, with kilns fired at controlled temperatures up to 1200 ºC. They forged similar tools like axes, hammers, chisels, saws, sickles, drills, nails, needles, textile looms, cattle ploughs, fishhooks and fishing nets. Their homes have turned up comparable razors, blades, copper mirrors, mortars, pestles and querns. They had similar architecture, town planning, drains and manhole covers, and brick-lined wells ‘ingeniously built with tapering bricks to prevent them from collapsing’. In some riverine sites, including Mohenjo-Daro, every third house on average had a private well, in addition to the public wells. ‘Many houses had waterproof bathing platforms and privies. Waste water was channeled away through pipes and chutes into covered drains that ran along level streets. The cesspits of these drains were regularly emptied.’[10] Their cities were usually oriented along cardinal directions. They seemingly also had a numbering system, at least in commercial use, that mixed binary and decimal—binary for small numbers, decimal for large.

The Harappan sites also had a fair bit of internal diversity, often shaped by geography. For instance, Dholavira lay in an arid zone and, compared to northern sites, focused a lot more on water harvesting and storage; its trade and material culture was more maritime than riverine; its funerary structures took many forms and differed from other regions’ Harappan sites